

Faith and music are the touchstones of the newly-minted Golden Globe winner's life. They explain why international fame has not moved the ground from beneath his feet.

A.R. RAHMAN

On a Song and a PRAYER

| By Kaveree Bamzai |

Kareema Begum, formerly known as Kasturi, is a slight woman, clad in a shiny blue zari-edged sari, every square centimetre of her worn fingers studded with diamonds, her sparkling toothy smile belying the struggles of her past. A single mother since 1976, she kept her four children together by renting out the two keyboards her husband, music composer R.K. Shekhar, had left her when he died of stomach cancer. Times were tough and her prodigiously talented son, then known as A.S. Dileep Kumar, was barely 11 when he started performing in public. "It got to the point where I had to go take him out of school every day to take him to performances," she recalls, speaking in Tamil, translated rapidly by Dileep Kumar a.k.a. Allah Rakha Rahman's imperious 12-year-old daughter. "He was in Class X. He told me I should either let him study or let him perform. We had to survive. He had to drop out of school," recalls Kareema. "I will always regret it."

What kept her going was what gives 43-year-old Rahman strength even today. Prayer and work. Influenced by a Sufi mystic, Karimullah Shah Qadri, in whom Kareema found solace as she battled her husband's illness, she converted the family to Islam in 1987. That faith drives her son today, with everything from the door to his recording studio to his mobile number bearing the holy numbers 786. And it is that faith that has seen him grow from the boy who played in several orchestras for a living to now being the man who has conquered the capital of the entertainment world, becoming the first Indian to win the

1997 **VANDE MATARAM**
Maa tujhe salaam redefines nationalism.
Flag waving suddenly becomes cool.

2002 **BOMBAY DREAMS**
Thanks to Shekhar Kapur, Andrew Lloyd
Webber asks him to compose for the musical.

2008 **SLUMDOG MILLIONAIRE**
Danny Boyle meets him in Chennai in June, Rahman
composes the score at his home in London in July.